THE MUSLIM VOTE CAN ONCE AGAIN CONSOLIDATE IF OPPOSITION PARTIES JOIN HANDS AGAINST THE BJP, SAY EXPERTS

vikas, sabka vishwas'," says Kunwar Basit Ali, head of the BJP's minority wing in the state. "In the Lok Sabha polls, too, Muslims won't get trapped in the divided opposition's narrative. They will vote for us."

According to Professor Kaviraj, who teaches political science at Lucknow University, the fragmentation of the Muslim vote is "definitely a concern for the Opposition". "By voting for the BSP, Congress and AIMIM in the local body elections, Muslims have sent out a message that they will not remain tied to a single party but will choose whichever candidate they feel is a better option for them." Dr Shilp Sikha Singh, also a Lucknow-based political scientist, feels the Muslim vote could once again consolidate behind the Opposition if the parties join hands against the BJP. SP spokesperson Fakrul Hasan Chand is also in favour of a united opposition to prevent any further division of Muslim votes, though he adds that the local body polls cannot be an indicator of how the community will vote in the general election.

But Shahnawaz Alam, chief of the Congress's minority wing in UP, claims Muslims have already shunned the SP. "They have decided to vote the Congress in the Lok Sabha election, as it is the only party that stood with them during the anti-CAA protests and on other issues concerning them," he says. Looks like the BJP will have another cakewalk in UP unless the opposition parties iron out their differences ahead of the general election in 2024. ■



WEST BENGAL

PRAGMATIC POLITICS

By Romita Datta

On the face of it, it was an impressive show of Opposition unity in the run-up to the general election next year: 19 senior leaders from 17 non-Congress Opposition parties attended the swearing-in ceremony of Karnataka's new chief minister Siddaramaiah, deputy CM D.K. Shivakumar and other Congress ministers in Bengaluru on May 20. Among those present were M.K. Stalin, Nitish Kumar and Hemant Soren—the chief ministers of Tamil Nadu, Bihar and Jharkhand, repectively—as well as Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD) leader Tejashwi Yadav, National Conference leader Farooq Abdullah, Nationalist Congress Party (NCP) chief Sharad Pawar and People's Democratic Party (PDP) leader Mehbooba Mufti. There were notable absences too—among them West Bengal chief minister Mamata Banerjee, who sent Trinamool Congress MP